

DREW JOHNSTON

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EDUCATION

Harvard University	Cambridge, MA
PhD, Economics	2019-2024
AM, Economics	2019-2022
Columbia University	New York, NY
BA, Computer Science and Economics	2013-2017

EXPERIENCE

OpenAI	New York, NY
Member of the Technical Staff (Data Scientist), Economic Research Team	2026-
Meta	New York, NY
Postdoctoral Research Scientist, Computational Social Science	2024-2026
Contractor, Central Applied Science	2023-2024
Contractor, Core Data Science	2018-2019, 2020-2023
Contractor, Feed Science	2017-2018
Opportunity Insights	Cambridge, MA
Research Collaborator	2024-
Graduate Research Assistant, Prof. Raj Chetty	2021-2024

WORKING PAPERS

Social Capital Around the World: Measurement, Determinants, and Effects

Revise & Resubmit at *Nature*

with Theresa Kuchler, Ayush Kumar, Johannes Stroebel, Manas Kulkarni, and Michael Bailey

Press: [La Vanguardia](#)

Social Ties and Residential Choice: Micro Evidence and Equilibrium Implications

with Martin Koenen

Social Capital in the United Kingdom: Evidence from Six Billion Friendships

with Tom Harris, Shankar Iyer, Tom Rutter, Guanghua Chi, Patrick Lam, Lucy Makinson, Antonio S. Silva, Martin Wessel, Mei-Chen Liou, Yingcan Wang, Qamar Zaman, Mike Bailey

Press: [The Economist](#), [The Guardian](#) (1), [The Guardian](#) (2), [The Independent](#), [The Times](#), [The Standard](#) (Data) ([Visualization](#))

PUBLICATIONS

The Social Connectedness Index: A Large-Scale Dataset of Social Ties across Geographic Locations

Data in Brief, 67(112905), June 2026

with Theresa Kuchler, Manas Kulkarni, Johannes Stroebel

([Data](#)) ([Visualization](#))

The Social Integration of International Migrants: Evidence from the Networks of Syrians in Germany

Journal of Political Economy, 134 (5), 1159-1209, April 2026

Best Poster at the *International Conference on Computational Social Science* (IC2S2 2022)

with Michael Bailey, Martin Koenen, Theresa Kuchler, Dominic Russel, Johannes Stroebel

([Appendix](#)) ([Data](#)) ([Slides](#)) ([Research Summary](#))

Cross-Gender Social Ties Around the World

American Economic Association Papers & Proceedings, 115, 132-38, May 2025.

with Michael Bailey, Theresa Kuchler, Ayush Kumar, Johannes Stroebel

Press: [The Economist](#), [SF Chronicle](#)

([Data](#)) ([Appendix](#)) ([Code](#))

Measuring Global Migration Flows using Online Data

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 122 (18) e2409418122, April 2025

with Guanghua Chi, Guy Abel, Eugenia Giraudy, Mike Bailey

Press: [New York Times \(1\)](#), [New York Times \(2\)](#)

(Data) (Appendix) (Code)

Social Networks Shape Beliefs and Behavior: Evidence from Social Distancing during the COVID-19 Pandemic

Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics, 2 (3), 463-494, August 2024

with Michael Bailey, Martin Koenen, Theresa Kuchler, Dominic Russel, Johannes Stroebe

Press: [NBER Digest](#)

(Appendix) (Code)

Social Capital I: Measurement and Associations with Economic Mobility

Nature, 608 (7921), 108-121. August 2022. (Cover Article)

with Raj Chetty, Matthew O. Jackson, Johannes Stroebe, Theresa Kuchler, Nathaniel Hendren, Robert Fluegge, Sara Gong, Federico Gonzalez, Armelle Grondin, Matthew Jacob, Martin Koenen, Eduardo Laguna-Muggenburg, Florian Mudekerez, Tom Rutter, Nicolaj Thor, Wilbur Townsend, Ruby Zhang, Mike Bailey, Pablo Barberá, Monica Bhole, Nils Wernerfelt

Press: [NYT \(1\)](#), [NYT \(2\)](#), [The Economist](#), [Washington Post](#), [NPR](#), [CBS](#), [Axios](#), [Brookings](#), [El País](#), [The Hill](#)
(Social Capital Atlas) (Data) (Slides) (Summary) (Appendix)

Social Capital II: Determinants of Economic Connectedness

Nature, 608 (7921), 122-134. August 2022.

with Raj Chetty, Matthew O. Jackson, Johannes Stroebe, Theresa Kuchler, Nathaniel Hendren, Robert Fluegge, Sara Gong, Federico Gonzalez, Armelle Grondin, Matthew Jacob, Martin Koenen, Eduardo Laguna-Muggenburg, Florian Mudekerez, Tom Rutter, Nicolaj Thor, Wilbur Townsend, Ruby Zhang, Mike Bailey, Pablo Barberá, Monica Bhole, Nils Wernerfelt

Peer Effects in Product Adoption

American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, 14 (3), 488-526, July 2022

with Michael Bailey, Theresa Kuchler, Johannes Stroebe, Arlene Wong

Press: [VoxEU](#), [LSE Business Review](#), [World Economic Forum](#)

(Code) (Appendix)

Social Connectedness in Europe

International Conference on Social Informatics (SocInfo 2020), 1-14, October 2020

with Michael Bailey, Theresa Kuchler, Dominic Russel, Bogdan State, Johannes Stroebe

Press: [Facebook Research](#)

(Data) (Code) (Appendix)

POLICY REPORTS

The War in Ukraine and the Potential of Facebook's Social Connectedness Index to Anticipate Human Displacement

UN International Organization for Migration: Migration Research Series, No. 73, April 2023

with Umberto Minora, Martina Belmonte, Claudia Bosco, Stefano Iacus, Eugenia Giraudy, Francesco Sermi

CONFERENCE & SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

2025	International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2)	(SweCSS)
	NSF Conference on Network Science and Economics	(Stanford)
	American Economic Association Meeting	(San Francisco)
2024	Digital Technologies and Sustainable Development Workshop	(Oxford)
	Barcelona Summer Forum (Migration)	(BSE)
2023	NSF Conference on Network Science and Economics	(Virginia Tech)
	European Networks Conference	(Central European University)
	Urban Economics Association European Meeting	(Bocconi)
	Summer School on the Economics of Migration	(UC Davis & Alianza MX)
2022	International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2)	(UChicago)
	Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics	(Stanford)

	Urban Economics Association Annual Meeting	(World Bank)
2021	Networks 2021 (Sunbelt & NetSci joint meeting)	(Virtual)
	Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	(Houston)
2020	Facebook Computational Social Science Seminar	(Virtual)

INVITED LECTURES, PANELS & PUBLIC SPEAKING

2026	EdLinks—AI & the Future of Work Panel	(SJF Ventures)
	Development Data Partnership Panel	(World Bank)
	United Nations Behavioral Science Week—Panel on AI & Human Agency	(Virtual)
2025	Sciences Po (Transdisciplinary Approaches to Inequality)	(Virtual)
2024	Urban Libraries Council Annual Meeting	(Washington, D.C.)
2023	Boston College Economics Honor Society	(Boston College)

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Refereeing: Nature, the Quarterly Journal of Economics ($\times 2$), the Review of Economics and Statistics, the Economic Journal, the Journal of Urban Economics ($\times 2$), PNAS Nexus, Management Science, and the Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society

Program Committee: FAcCT '23 (ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency)

OTHER

Member, Brooklyn Community Board 9	2025-
Member, Social Capital Lab	
Affiliated Researcher, Laboratorio de Oportunidades (Spain)	
Affiliate, Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science	
2x NCAA Team Fencing Champion	